

BOTTOMS UP

It's time to reinvent the everyday trouser as pants play with styles and silhouettes and women's wear gets innovative

■ By Kimi Dangor

Fashion forecasters will readily tell you breeches are riding the fashion wave this season. Royal reinforcement moves from the ramps on to racks in the form of jodhpurs, hitherto confined to Raghavendra Rathore's Rajasthan stamped design lineage. But even as riding pants become the latest buzzword in men's fashion, women aren't far behind in the joust. With Rohit Bal, Tarun Tahliani and Gayatri Khanna dressing femmes in breeches, here's a trend that's all set to give the everyday trouser a total makeover.

As the trendmill turns, fashion gets playful and brings trousers with higher waistlines, skin skimming cuts, lower crotches, playing up on

voluminous palazzos and gathered dhoti pants. From Alexander McQueen to Ashish Soni, Malini Ramani and Monisha Jaising, churi pants have plundered many runways and have trickled down to our trendy high streets. But even as you pontificate on whether churi pants will flatter your ample curves, fear not, this is the season to widen your horizons, move beyond the drainpipe and experiment, innovate and adapt for the Indian fashionista. Veteran virtuoso J.J. Valaya lays great emphasis on the importance of lowers. "They are an important element of fine dressing. Everybody likes to experiment with the obviously more visible upper, but only a true style maker would go beyond and

focus on the complete look," he says.

While catwalk couture dictates a free-for-all, young designers like Arjun Saluja, Nikasha Tawadey and Gaurav Gupta play on volume with dhoti pants, cowed hips and drop crotches. Even as jodhpurs reign supreme on runways, the ultra-low thong-show is taking a fashionable back-seat. On high streets, the ever-popular jeans too have seen a fashionable rise and fall with boot-cuts giving way to slim skin fits, baggy bottoms and slowly rising waists as seen at the Levi's show at Lakme Fashion Week. Everything from dongri denim capris to churidar-inspired jeans and the hot 'new' high-rise skinny made it to the runway.

"Indian women are now open to different silhouettes," says Tawadey, who experimented with dogri pants and dhoti skirts in her spring-summer 2008 line. "A lot of this experimentation we are seeing

Photographs by SHIRYA PATIL
Models: ERIKA PACKARD, KANISHKA DHANRAJ
COURTESY ELITE MODEL MANAGEMENT
Jewellery: GRAND HYATT MUMBAI

DHOTI PANTS

A loose-fitting trouser interpretation of the pleated local dhoti, with a drop crotch; has been redefined by Nikasha Tawadey.

WIDE-LEGGED PANTS

Trousers with wide-bottomed hems and high waists often termed as palazzos, these are ideal for lounge wear, as seen in Gayatri Khanna's creation.

